

REVIEW OF BIRD & WILDLIFE –WATCHING and CULTURAL TOUR TO INDIA - WITH VIGT

(VARDHAN INDIVIDUAL & GUIDED TOURS) : 20 FEB - 6 MAR 2015

After a chance meeting at the Rutland Bird Fair in August 2014 with Manoj Vardhan of VIGT Tours, and subsequently reading testimonials of previous tour guests, three of us decided we would like to take one of VIGT's "history, culture and wildlife" tours in India. Although principally birdwatchers, all three of us particularly wanted to see Tigers in the wild also to experience some Indian culture and history. We were not disappointed.

All the tour & travel arrangements were put together in advance by VIGT, the two principal areas for Tiger opportunities being Corbett NP & Ranthmbhore NP and for history / cultural interest Agra and Jaipur areas. As the arrangements were mostly made by e-mail between UK and India this process was a little drawn out but Manoj and his team were patient in providing clarification and answering all our various queries.

So we set off from Birmingham International Airport on the morning of the 19th of February 2015, flying by Emirates to New Delhi Airport via Dubai. On arrival in New Delhi 9am local time on 20th February we were met by Manoj and his driver Mangal who drove us to our hotel for one night, the [Home@f37](#). House Crow, Common Myna, Black Kite & Feral Pigeons were our first Indian birds!

On arriving Manoj gave us all a welcome pack for the holiday and met us later for a meal to talk about the holiday. Originally the itinerary included an overnight train from New Delhi to Ramnagar on the night of our arrival, but fearing being too "jet lagged", we had the itinerary amended to stay overnight at the hotel and take an early morning car journey to Ramnagar rather than the train. This was definitely a good decision. New birds en route included Black Drongo, Brahminy Kite, Punjab Raven, Red Jungle Fowl and River Lapwing.

After a long drive to Ramnagar we were met by Anil and Sonhu who were our guide and driver for the next (three) days. Here we changed from the car to an open "Gypsy" jeep that was our transport whilst in the Corbett NP and Nainital / Himalayan foothills areas. Anil and Sonhu loaded our luggage into the jeep (it was a little cramped until we could offload our luggage later in the day) and then drove us to Corbett NP where we stopped for lunch. After lunch we drove into the park and started to see the incredible birds which this area had in abundance. Highlights of the first "safari" included Scarlet Minivet, Plumbeous Water Redstart, White-Capped Water Redstart, Kalij Pheasant and White-Throated Fantail.

Our base was to be Dhikala Camp which we reached early evening to book in at the lodge. Then for our meal. There were two game drives on the morning and afternoon of the 22nd. After the morning drive we went back to camp for our meal. Tigers were reported but Anil and Sonhu were helpfully concentrating on the bird life for us - it was incredible, and as it was our first visit to the Indian sub-continent we were seeing new species to us at every turn. It was a little overwhelming – often we did not know where to look next!!.

On the 23rd we decided to go on the early morning elephant ride. This was a great experience, excellent vantage point, and felt surprisingly safe and relaxing; we were concentrating now on looking for tiger. Although reportedly in the area, after nearly 2 hours it looked as though we were out of luck as we were crossing grassland back to the lodge. Then Anil spotted a male to our left

forward of the elephant moving through the undergrowth. A brief view then it was off - low through the grass. We thought that was it until a few moments later it suddenly was there again right in front of us - we heard a deep growl and the tiger raised itself up as if to leap at the elephant before pulling out and moving away. Very exciting but a very brief encounter, with only a couple of grabbed photos, but we felt lucky with what we had seen. After collecting the luggage we left the area with a last game drive. Once again the birds did not disappoint us. We were then driven to Karan's Corbett Motel for our overnight stay. Brown Dipper was seen at the one site along with sunbirds.

On the 24th we drove from the Motel to the Jim Corbett Museum and then into the hills in the Bajun area for our next base at the Vikram Village Hotel. On the 25th we went bird watching in the Pangol area looking for special birds of the area, most of which we saw. On the 26th from Nainital we went to Sat Tal looking for Red-billed Leiothrix which we saw with the help of Anil. The rain started quite heavily so we only had a brief stop at the rubbish dump but there were a large number of Steppe Eagles sat fairly close in trees. No doubt this have provided good flight views and been much better in sunlight. Spotted Forktails were seen on the 25th. Driving back towards Karan's Corbett Motel we stopped at the barrage and spotted Wallcreeper - a "bogey bird" for most of us.

After a meal Sonhu drove us to Ramnagar station for our train to New Delhi. We had been told someone would help us on with our luggage as it was late on the evening, but unexpectedly we were left on the platform with all our luggage and no-one to help us onto the correct train or to load our luggage. This was the low-spot of the holiday and did cause us stress. Also we were in an open sleeper carriage not an individual cabin as we had been advised. With all our gear this made it awkward and we did not get much sleep on the train. Mangal our original driver met us at 4.10am at the station on the 27th and then took us for a drink and some food. About 7am he helped us onto the train at 7am (Taj Express) for Agra. Unfortunately we got off one station too soon (fortunately only a few miles out of Agra) but a phone call to Manoj and this was promptly resolved - we were shortly collected and taken to our hotel - The Howard Plaza. (Not for the first time would we were glad of the mobile phones and the Indian SIM cards we had purchased in New Delhi, they were a real help) On the afternoon Prakesh and our guide Ajay drove us to the Red Fort and we looked at the Taj Mahal from the opposite bank of the river. And then on to visit some traditional skilled craftsmen - a hand woven carpet factory and a place where we were told we would see "The Star Of India" (turned out to be a jewellery shop!) Although the traditional method of carpet making was quite interesting for us to see, and we did choose to make some purchases, we were unprepared for the hard "sales pitch" that we were presented with at these places. This we strongly felt should have been made clear from the outset i.e. that there would also be a sales pitch and that we were under no obligation to buy if we did not wish to do so. Manoj Vardhan later agreed that this should have been made clear to us. Prakesh then drove us back to the hotel for our meal.

On the morning of the 28th of February Prakesh and Ajay drove us to the Taj Mahal and we saw it with the morning sun slowly changing its colours and the marble shining. What can you say it was incredible. Once again there was a visit to a craftsman but this time Ajay did say there was a opportunity to buy but under no obligation. Ajay was also willing to learn more about some of the birds seen so he could improve his knowledge. Ajay was also helpful by taking us to get some sterling changed into rupees on this day too. Back to the hotel for lunch and change of clothes then driven to Bharatpur Junction to catch the train to our next destination, Ranthambhore NP.

Although the train was due to leave around 4pm on a 2 hour journey, it did not leave until after 5pm and did arrive until after 9.30pm at Sawai Madhhopur station. Manoj met us here and porters helped us with our luggage and drove us to Tigers Retreat Hotel, our base here.

The first game drive on the morning of 1st of March was Route 6, which was a very rocky drive. It seems that the drivers in their enthusiasm to get their guests good views of tigers place their comfort secondary! We were buffeted about so much that it was impossible to take any photos en route, so much so that we had to ask Raj our guide to proceed more gently, after which the journey was much more comfortable. We did look for tiger but saw birds and mongoose. After lunch Raj had managed to get us on the Route 3 the best one for Tiger sightings.

Having seen a tiger at Corbett we were not really expecting to have any more views – as we had spoken to several people who had had no sightings after several visits. How wrong could we have been?! We stopped by the large lake and on the opposite bank (about 200 yards away) was a tigress with not one but three year-old cubs. Watching them play for around 30 minutes with their mother was superb and beyond our dreams. Lots of photos taken this time! However Raj saw the female moving off and decided to move our jeep to a better spot to see her. Then WOW she was walking left to right in front of our jeep about 8 to 10 foot – completely indifferent to our presence. She stopped, looked over the lake and then slowly walked back right to left. What can you say she was magnificent and we were very lucky all thanks to Raj and the driver. After these excellent views heavy rain started to fall so we drove back to the hotel. There was no rain cover on this jeep so we were literally soaked to the skin, but happy nevertheless!

Our morning drive on the 2nd was delayed due to the rain and flooding but we did have a short drive to an area little visited normally, looking for leopard and vulture. The vulture was seen but not the leopard. On the afternoon Raj then took us to Lake Surwal for its birds and once again we were not disappointed. Flamingoes, Spoonbills, Indian Skimmers, gulls, pelicans, egrets and herons, also Great Thick-Knee seen here. In nearby open plains Nilgai were also seen along with the rare Blackbuck. The driver was EXCELLENT and got us back over very muddy and wet roads. (it felt like driving along a canal at one point!) On the morning drive on Route 4, Kenny our guide took us to one spot for birds and were rewarded with them all around us including at least three species of woodpeckers, plus Indian Roller. On the afternoon a different guide took us on route 2 which once again was very good and they very patient with our need to take photographs. On the evening we looked for Sandgrouse, immediately outside the lodge, we saw a few Painted Sandgrouse in failing light - probably due to the rainfall giving them alternative watering areas to fly to. On the morning of the 4th of March the driver that was with us for lake Sarwal drove us to visit Ranthambhore Fort. Here there were great views from the elevated viewpoint, also opportunity to visit a Hindu temple. From the edge of the Fort local people were feeding the fish, which are apparently sacred to them. This was yet another incredible experience before driving back to the hotel.

Due to the delays in arriving here by train we opted to change the itinerary for the end of the holiday to avoid further train journeys, so decided to be taken to Jaipur (and also on to New Delhi) by car instead. Due to the increased journey time travelling by car this did unfortunately mean that we did have to miss out some of the planned cultural visits (*Hawar Mahal, Stone Observatory and Fatehpur Sikri tomb.*)

Manoj and his driver picked us up and drove us to our Hotel for the night. At 7pm Manoj picked us up and took us to his home in Jaipur for a meal and to meet his family. This was a great way to end to this part of the holiday. A visit with an Indian family had been included in a prior version of our itinerary and we were very glad that this part of the tour was reinstated! It really was an honour and a pleasure to meet his wife, children, father and mother.

On the 5th of March we visited Man Sagar Lake a local nature reserve where Manoj's father Harsh

Vardhan is, together with friends, helping to improve the biodiversity of the lake, and where he holds the annual Indian Bird Fair. In the afternoon we drove on to New Delhi with an overnight stop at Hotel Shanti Palace before our return flight in the morning. Early on the 6th we left for the airport and home.

Overall the tour was a wonderful experience. We were well looked after at the hotels and lodges – staff (particularly at Tigers Retreat) could not have been any more attentive and courteous. Also all the guides were very helpful, knowledgeable and patient, especially Anil and Sonhu. Drivers were also excellent and, despite the volume of traffic, constant sounding of horns, variable condition of road surfaces plus the many hazards met on Indian roads (*cattle, camels, elephants, vehicles driving against the flow of traffic, wide & tall loads etc etc.*) – never did we feel unsafe (*apart from perhaps on the first Ranthambhor safari on Route 6, as mentioned above!*)

Apart from the problem with the first train everything in the itinerary worked pretty smoothly and as expected, and Manoj was supportive and happily amended the itinerary as necessary to fit in with what we wanted. We were glad that we had arranged (at extra cost) to only have the three of us in our jeeps – felt worth the extra money asking as it gave us more opportunities to photograph. Some of the other safari vehicles looked very tightly packed which would have been a problem for us, particularly for photography.

In total we saw around 265 species of birds (including one sub-species) as well as 23 species of other wildlife. The Tigers were incredible but to also see both Blackbuck and the Indian Gazelle, both rare, was a treat. The people, the sounds, the colours of India are things that will stay with us for a long time. The food was excellent too!

Paul Hobbs & Mike Box, Birmingham, 28 August 2015

- ***If anyone wants a more detailed breakdown of the bird species seen or to know any more about our tour, please contact Mike Box by e-mail on:- box123v@tiscali.co.uk***

Cautionary Postscript.

Photographers in particular need to be aware of the strict rules re excess hold baggage. One of us paid in advance £100 excess baggage charge to carry a further 5Kg over the standard 30Kg allowance as he realised (even with the other 2 carrying some of his gear within their 30Kg allowance) that his luggage would personally be over 30Kg and Emirates website says “group” hold allowance are NOT aggregated.

*As it transpired our hold luggage **WAS** aggregated (without us requesting this) and was only 87Kg on outward journey (ie 3Kg below the aggregated allowance of 90Kg) so he could have avoided the extra £100.*

On the return journey we had (surprisingly) acquired a further 18 Kg and our total hold luggage (again aggregated - without our request - contrary to what Emirates website says) was clearly now above the 90Kg aggregated limit so our photographer had to pay a further £375 on the return journey – “fair enough” based on Emirates rules.

But Emirates have refused to refund the £100 wrongly paid in advance despite the further £375 paid on the return journey!!!

Birds seen in India 20 Feb – 6 Mar 2015:-

Altai Accentor
Ashy Bulbul
Ashy Drongo
Ashy Prinia
Ashy-crowned Sparrow-Lark
Asian Barred Owlet
Asian Great Tit
Asian House Martin (White-rumped Martin)
Asian Openbill
Asian Pied Starling
Bank Myna
Bar-headed Goose
Bar-winged Flycatcher-Shrike
Barn Swallow
Black Bulbul
Black Drongo
Black Eagle
Black Kite
Black Redstart
Black Stork
Black-eared Kite
Black-headed Bulbul
Black-headed Ibis
Black-headed Jay
Black-hooded Drongo
Black-hooded Oriole
Black-lored Tit
Black-necked Stork
Black-tailed Godwit
Black-throated Tit
Black-winged Kite
Black-winged Stilt
Blue Rock Thrush
Blue Whistling Thrush
Blue-fronted Redstart
Blue-throated Barbet
Blue-winged Siva
Brahminy Kite
Brahminy Starling
Bronze-winged Jacana
Brown Dipper
Brown Fish Owl
Brown Rock Chat
Brown Shrike
Brown-capped Pigmy Woodpecker
Brown-fronted Woodpecker
Brown-headed Gull
Cattle Egret
Changeable Hawk Eagle
Chestnut-bellied Nuthatch

Chestnut-bellied Rock Thrush
Chestnut-crowned Laughing Thrush
Chestnut-eared Bunting
Chestnut-shouldered Petronia (Yellow-throated Sparrow)
Cinnerous Vulture
Collared Falconet
Collared Scops Owl
Common Green Magpie
Common Greenshank
Common Hill Myna
Common Hoopoe
Common Kestrel
Common Kingfisher
Common Moorhen
Common Myna
Common / Feral Pigeon (Rock Dove)
Common Redshank
Common Sandpiper
Common Snipe
Common Starling
Common Stonechat
Common Swift
Common Tailorbird
Common Teal
Common Woodshrike
Crested Hawk Eagle
Crested Serpent Eagle
Crimson Sunbird
Dalmatian Pelican
Dark-Sided Flycatcher (or similar)
Darter (Oriental Darter / Snake Bird / Anhinga)
Dusky Crag Martin
Egyptian Vulture
Eurasian Collared Dove
Eurasian Coot
Eurasian Jay
Eurasian Marsh Harrier
Eurasian Sparrowhawk
Eurasian Spoonbill
Eurasian Wigeon
Eurasian Wryneck
Garganey
Golden-fronted Leafbird
Great Barbet
Great Cormorant
Great Egret
Great Hornbill
Great Thick-knee
Great White Pelican
Greater Flamingo
Greater Goldenback
Greater Pied Kingfisher (formerly Crested Kingfisher)
Greater Yellownape
Green Bee-eater

Green Sandpiper
Green-backed Tit
Green-billed Malkoha
Green-tailed Sunbird
Greenshank
Grey Bushchat
Grey Francolin
Grey Heron
Grey Wagtail
Grey-backed Shrike
Grey-capped Pygmy Woodpecker
Grey-headed Canary Flycatcher
Grey-headed Woodpecker
Grey-hooded Warbler
Grey-winged Blackbird
Greylag Goose
Gull-billed Tern
Himalayan Bluetail
Himalayan Bulbul
Himalayan Vulture
Himalayan Woodpecker
Hodgson's Treecreeper
House Crow
House Sparrow
House Swift
Indian Coal Tit
Indian Cormorant
Indian Jungle Crow
Indian Peafowl
Indian Pond Heron
Indian Robin
Indian Roller
Indian Silverbill
Indian Skimmer
Indian Spot-billed Duck
Indian Vulture (Long-billed Vulture)
Intermediate Egret
Jungle Babbler
Jungle Bush Quail
Jungle Owlet
Kalij Pheasant
King Vulture/Red-headed
Knob-billed Duck (Comb Duck)
Koklass Pheasant
Lammergeier
Large Cuckoo Shrike
Large Grey Babbler
Large-billed Crow
Laughing Dove
Lesser Goldenback (Woodpecker)
Lesser Pied Kingfisher
Lesser Whistling-duck
Lesser Yellownape (Woodpecker)
Lineated Barbet

Little Cormorant
Little Egret
Little Grebe
Little Ringed Plover
Long-tailed Minivet
Long-tailed Shrike
Long-Tailed Shrike - Tricolor (sub spp)
Maroon Oriole
Marsh Sandpiper
Merlin
Mountain Bulbul
Northern Pintail
Northern Shoveler
Orange-bellied Leafbird
Oriental Honey Buzzard
Oriental Magpie Robin
Oriental Pied Hornbill
Oriental Skylark
Oriental Turtle Dove
Oriental White-eye
Osprey
Paddyfield Pipit
Painted Sandgrouse
Painted Snipe
Painted Spur Fowl
Painted Stork
Pallas's Fish Eagle
Peregrine Falcon (or similar)
Pied Bushchat
Pied Wagtail
Plain Prinia
Plum-headed Parakeet
Plumbeous Water Redstart
Punjab Raven
Purple Heron
Purple Sunbird
Purple Swampphen (Purple Gallinule)
Red Avadavat
Red Jungle Fowl
Red-backed Shrike
Red-billed Blue Magpie
Red-billed Leiothrix
Red-billed Magpie
Red-breasted Parakeet
Red-crested Pochard
Red-headed Vulture (King Vulture)
Red-vented Bulbul
Red-wattled Lapwing
Red-whiskered Bulbul
River Lapwing
River Tern
Rose-ringed Parakeet
Rosy Starling
Ruddy Shelduck

Ruff
Rufous Sibia
Rufous Treepie
Rufous-backed Sibia
Russett Sparrow (Cinnamon Sparrow)
Rusty-Cheeked Babbler
Scaly-bellied Woodpecker
Scarlet Minivet
Shikra
Short-toed Snake Eagle
Slaty-headed Parakeet
Small Minivet
Small Niltava
Southern Coucal
Southern Grey Shrike
Spangled Drongo
Spot-winged Grosbeak
Spotted Dove
Spotted Forktail
Spotted Owlet
Spotted Redshank
Steppe Eagle
Stork-billed Kingfisher
Streak-throated Woodpecker
Streaked Laughing Thrush
Striated Heron
Striated Prinia
Tawny Eagle
Tawny Pipit
Two-barred Warbler
Velvet-fronted Nuthatch
Verditer Flycatcher
Wallcreeper
Water Pipit
Whiskered Yuhina
White Wagtail
White-bellied Drongo
White-bellied Minivet
White-breasted Waterhen
White-browed Fantail
White-browed Wagtail
White-capped Water Redstart
White-tailed Nuthatch
White-throated Fantail
White-throated Kingfisher
White-throated Laughing Thrush
Wood Sandpiper
Wooly-necked Stork
Yellow Wagtail
Yellow-bellied Fantail
Yellow-bellied Prinia
Yellow-Crowned Woodpecker
Yellow-footed Green Pigeon
Yellow-wattled Lapwing

Other Wildlife seen in India 20 Feb – 6 Mar 2015:-

Black Buck
Black-tailed Mongoose / Ruddy Mongoose
Brown Mongoose
Golden Jackal
Common (Northern Plains) Langur Monkeys
Five-striped Ground Squirrel
Gharial
Hog Deer
Himalayan Langur
Indian Elephants (wild and "tame")
Indian Gazelle
Indian (or Red) Muntjac (Barking Deer)
Indian Hare
Indian Softshell Turtle
Mountain Goat
Mugger Crocodile
Nilgai / Blue Bull
Rhesus Macaque Monkey
Sambar Deer
Small Turtle
Spotted Deer / Chital
Tiger (Male at Corbett, Female "Unnis" & Year-old cubs (3) at Ranthambhor)
Water Buffalo
Wild Boar

Postscript:-

I have since found out some more information on the Internet about the Tigers we saw in Ranthambhor. The mother Tiger is named Unnis (also called Krishna) and is a daughter of the famous Tigress Machli who has featured in several wildlife documentaries such as "Tiger Dynasty" and "Queen Of Tigers", she was one of 3 female cubs in Machli's 4th and final litter in Autumn 2006, so Unnis was about 8 & 1/2 years old when we saw her with her cubs.